

2001. This is our year.

The year of influence!

The word influence means *to make an impact; the effect of one thing upon another*. It literally means, "to pour into." In other words, if we want to make an impact in a certain area, we will have to pour into that particular area. To truly influence and touch our city we will have to concentrate on four critical characteristics: fervent *prayer*, our specific *purpose* as a church, strategic and anointed *planning*, and supernatural *provision*.

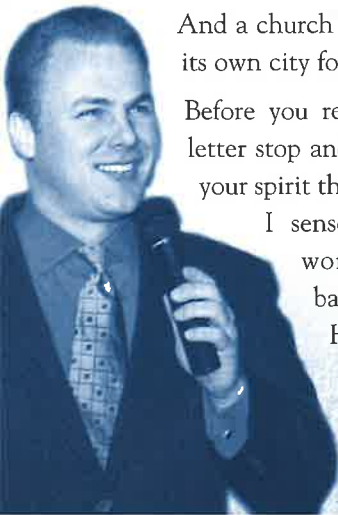
Our focus on corporate prayer is nothing new or unprecedented. In the book of Acts they waited and prayed until the power of the Holy Spirit came to equip them for the great task at hand. That equipping power came as they prayed continually. It's the same today. We have an intense vision so we need intense power. The power will come through intense prayer.

We also know our purpose: to build a large, thriving, life-giving church in the city of Memphis; a growing, Spirit-filled church with a vision. A church committed to powerful worship and balanced, Bible-centered teaching. A church that reaches and raises-up laborers. A church committed to world missions.

And a church positioned to touch its own city for Jesus Christ!

Before you read the rest of this letter stop and ask God to stir in your spirit the same urgency that

I sense as I write these words. Ask God to baptize you afresh in His fire. It's going to be a powerful year... *a year of influence.*



Touching our City

Acts 1:8 - "...and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem..."

The vision had to begin with Jerusalem! For hundreds of years, Jerusalem had been a place of destiny. Now as Jesus prepared to depart, the spiritual future of Jerusalem and the rest of the world was in the hands of a few. Reaching Jerusalem wasn't just a matter of proximity; it was a matter of priority! The same is true for us. It has to begin with our Jerusalem, our own city, Memphis, Tennessee.



We will continue our support of Breakthrough Memphis, our own non-profit community development corporation that touches the forgotten people of our city in a variety of ways. This year we will partner with Breakthrough Memphis in hosting two Holiday VIP Dinners, the first at Easter and the second at Christmas.

As we have been fasting and praying and seeking God's plan for our church this year, the Holy Spirit has challenged us to invest significantly in multi-media. We are planning to use billboards, television and radio as well as other media to let our city know that we are here. We have always said that we would rather be ignored than not known. Many who have joined us have said, "I wish I would have known about you sooner, but I didn't know you were here." Our goal is to establish The Life Church as a permanent presence in the city of Memphis.

With every God-given plan comes sacrifice. In fact, one of the first signs of revival is the powerful wind of sacrificial financial giving that blows through God's church. As in the book of Acts, we have the opportunity to be involved in the supernatural provision!

Spread throughout the year 2001 will be 4 special memorial offerings that will be specifically invested in touching our city. Each offering will enable us to invest in multi-media for the three months following the offering. Therefore, we will only do as much as each offering provides. The first offering will be **Sunday, February 4**, during our *Touching our City, Reaching the World Conference*. The three remaining offerings will be received on April 29, July 29, and November 4.

Together we can touch our city in a powerful way!

Reaching the World

Acts 1:8 - "...and to the ends of the earth."

This Acts 1:8 pattern was more than just an effective itinerary. Jesus was again sending us a message concerning His heart for the nations. While we must commit to touching our city, we must also obey the call to reach the world. Our heart for the world can be expressed with four main words:

Pray - Our goal is to be a prayer-shield for the missionaries we support and a powerful source of intercession for the many unreached people groups around the world.

Give - We are committed to investing 10% of our undesignated church income toward world missions. This is the church's tithe! A majority of this money is spent on monthly commitments to ministries and missionaries serving in seven different nations of the world - Australia, Belgium, Brazil, Kenya, Mexico, Peru, and Sri-Lanka. In addition, we invest in short-term mission trips and other projects.

Go - Each and every believer should take at least one missions trip! Each year approximately forty members of our church are involved in one of these trips. Take a step of faith and sign-up to join one of these teams in 2001. It will change your life forever.

Send - The day will soon come when we will send out teams of trained missionaries, from our own church, to plant cell churches in foreign fields.

Beginning with our *Touching our City, Reaching the World Conference* and extending through our last short-term missions trip, this year will no doubt prove to be a year of tremendous influence.

Get ready. Get set. Let's GO!

PASTOR JOHN

